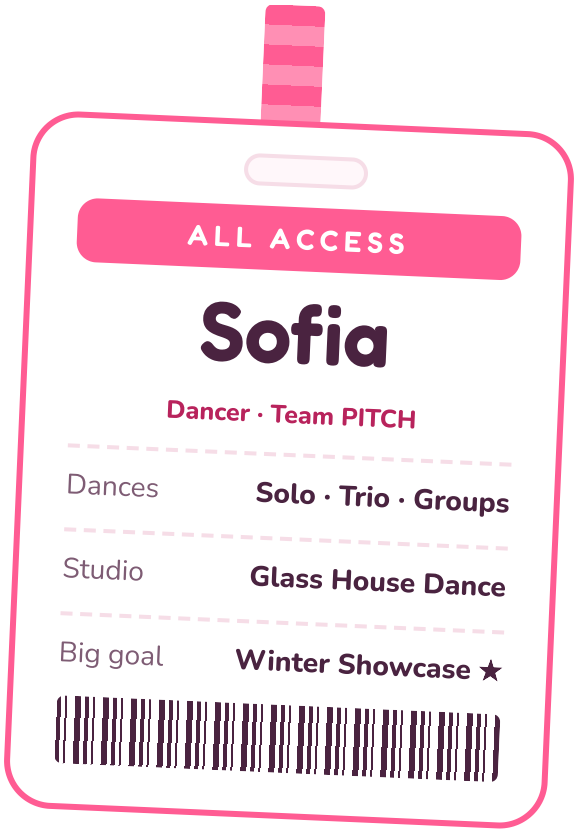
FOR SOFIA · SEASON 2026–27

# Your backstage pass

This season you have three helpers: the **Spotlight app**, your **Practice Toolkit** and your **Season Workbook**. Like a stage crew, each one has its own job. Here's who does what, what to grab when, and how to keep dance, school, home and fun all feeling good.




## If you remember only five things

- ★ **App = today. Toolkit = how. Workbook = everything else.**
- ★ A little practice most days beats one giant practice.
- ★ A teacher's correction goes into your practice right away.
- ★ Sleep 9–12 hours. Your brain practices while you sleep.
- ★ Dance, school, home and fun each get some time every week.

PART 1

# Meet your crew

Three helpers, three different jobs. None of them does everything.

PHONE OR TABLET

## Spotlight app

*The coach in your pocket*

**Tells you what to do TODAY.**

- **Today:** the plan for today and Ms. Brittany's homework
- ▶ **Start practice:** music, timer and every step in order
- **Your solo:** practice player and Memorize (Chunks, Pause & Predict, Cue cards)
- **Sunday:** film your solo, then the Sunday sheet with Mom
- Stars, streaks and games
- Counts down the days to the show

PAPER · 8 PAGES

## Practice Toolkit

*Your practice map*

**Shows HOW to practice and how far you've come.**

- **p.1** The plan, the big checkpoints, your week
- **p.2** Sticker tracker: Thu, Fri, Sun, My one fix, the ◀ THIS WEEK clip
- **p.2b** The countdown and My rewards
- **p.2c** My week
- **p.3** How to practice + Show in your head
- **p.4** Solo map, your fixes, the trick ladder
- **p.5** Trio memory map and counts
- **p.6** This week: a fresh sheet every Sunday

PAPER · 16 PAGES, 6 IN YOUR BINDER

## Season Workbook

*Your dancer's handbook*

**EVERYTHING ELSE about the season.**

- **p.5–6** Group dances: PITCH jazz + contemporary
- **p.9** Show day, nerves, "if it goes wrong"
- **p.10** Music, people, costumes
- **p.11** Packing lists
- **p.14** Count sheets

**App = TODAY** **Toolkit = HOW** **Workbook = EVERYTHING ELSE**

## All your paper lives in one binder

Six tabs, in this order. Each divider says what's behind it.

**1 Start here**

This guide

**2 My plan**

Toolkit p.1 the plan · p.2 tracker · p.2b countdown + rewards · p.2c My week · p.6 This week

**3 Practice**

Toolkit p.3 how to practice · Workbook p.14 count sheets

**4 My dances**

Toolkit p.4 solo · p.5 trio · Workbook p.5–6 group dances

**5 Aerial**

Aerial Mission: the drills, the plan, the checklist

**6 Show time**

Workbook p.9 show day + nerves · p.11 packing · p.10 music + people

### If two helpers say different things

**Your teachers** › the app › the Toolkit › the Workbook

Teachers always win. After that, the newest helper wins, and the app is the newest.

PART 2

# What do I grab?

Find your moment on the left. The chip says which helper to grab.

| | |
|---|---|
| **What do I practice today?** | App<br>Open Today. It shows the plan and how long it takes. |
| **It's a home practice day** | App · Toolkit p.4<br>Tap ▶ Start practice. Keep page 4 open next to you so you can see your fixes. |
| **I finished!** | App · Toolkit p.2<br>When the app says ★ Plan done, put a sticker on page 2. Three in a week = a full week ★ |

| | |
|---|---|
| **A part of my solo keeps slipping** | App<br>Dances, your solo, Memorize. Chunks plays one piece at a time, Pause & Predict asks what comes next. One 8-count at a time, then join it to the one before. |
| **A teacher gave me a correction** | App Toolkit p.6<br>Tell Mom and add it with + Note on that dance. Write it on This week. It becomes your fix right away. Corrections from Saturday group rehearsal count too. |
| **It's Sunday** | App Toolkit p.2 + p.6<br>Film your solo, then open the Sunday sheet on Today. It walks you and Mom through it: watch the last run, say what went well, then ✓ It showed or Not yet for your one fix. Write the fix on page 2 and fill in a new page 6. |
| **Group dances** | Workbook p.5–6<br>The big groups practice at Saturday rehearsal. At home, only if you got a correction. Their pages are behind the My dances tab. |
| **Aerial drills** | Aerial tab<br>Mat under you, every time. First tries happen in Monday Acro with a coach. At home, Mom films and holds the mat. |
| **Packing for a show** | Workbook p.11<br>Show time tab. Use the packing list and pack the night before. |
| **Butterflies before the show** | Workbook p.9<br>Show time tab. Do your "before you go on" routine. Then breathe: smell the flower, blow out the candle. |
| **Show in your head (starts Nov 9)** | Toolkit p.3<br>Music on, screen face down, eyes closed. Dance the whole solo in your head. |

PART 3

# The big goal, in small steps

THE BIG GOAL

**Dance your solo at the Winter Showcase from memory: your biggest, best dancing, eyes up, holding the ending to the very last note. And love doing it.**

Four parts get you there, one after the other. Don't skip ahead.

## 1
### Own it
**Sep 28 – Nov 8**

Know every step by heart. No video, nobody to follow. Memory + knees: no new tricks yet.

## 2
### Clean it
**Nov 9 – Nov 29**

Make it sharp: feet, knees, arms, eyes. One fix at a time. Show in your head starts.

## 3
### Perform it
**Nov 30 – Jan 3**

Dance it like the real show: your biggest, best dancing, costume on. Show your family at home.

## 4
### Rest up
**Jan 4 – the show**

Fewer runs from Dec 28. Less work, more rest. Nothing new. Fresh legs, calm head, early nights.

## How you get there

- ☐ **One 8-count at a time.** Learn it, then join it to the one before.
- ☐ **One fix at a time.** It's done when it shows on two videos in a row.
- ☐ **A short practice most days.** 35–45 minutes at home is plenty.
- ☐ **Never more than 2 days without your solo.** On busy days, the memory run counts (and on Monday, Hannah's videos and picturing it).
- ☐ **Finish lines get prizes.** Your finish lines are on Today's season card and on Toolkit page 1. When you make one, tap ✓ Made it with Mom, then pick a reward and write it on Toolkit page 2b: a movie night, a new scrunchie, choosing Saturday breakfast.
- ☐ **How ready?** Tap How ready? on Today to see four bars for your solo. Pause & Predict fills Know, fixes that showed fill Clean, your eight tricks fill Tricks, full runs and Sunday films fill Perform.

PART 4

# Your week

The same rhythm every week, so you always know what's next.

Studio · Home practice · Memory run

## Mon

Studio

**Ballet · Acro · Jazz Tech**

4:30–7:30

Watch Hannah's videos; picture the solo in the car. No dancing tonight. Homework first, early bed.

## Tue

Studio

**Hip Hop · Ballroom**

5:30–7:30

Memory run.

## Wed

Studio

**Contemporary**

6:30–7:30

+ memory run Solo rehearsal when one is booked.

## Thu

Home

**Strong + bendy + technique · your fix · knees or a trick · aerial strength (from Nov 9) · solo + trio**

35–45 min

## Fri

Home

**The same as Thursday, with aerial drills (from Nov 9)**

35–45 min

## Sat

Studio

**Co Tech · PITCH rehearsal**

10:00–12:15

+ memory run The big groups practice here.

## Sun

Home

**The session + film the solo + trio + film review**

40–45 min

Film review = the Sunday sheet. Plan your week on Toolkit p.6.

Trio privates with Larisa: at least 2 a month (30 min). On any day with a class, rehearsal or extra class, home practice is the short one: the memory run. When the studio is closed (Nov 25–29, Dec 19–Jan 1), class days are home days.

PART 5

# Keep all four spotlights on

A happy dancer has four lights. Each one gets some time every week, and none of them should go dark.

### Dance

Classes plus short home practices. That's enough. More isn't always better.

### School

Homework first on studio days. Read a little every day. Ask for help early, before it piles up.

### Home

Chores are teamwork: pack your dance bag and put it by the door, help with dinner, and tidy your dance spot in 2 minutes.

### Fun

Friends, playing outside, drawing, family time, even doing nothing at all. Fun is part of the plan.

### Does it feel like too much?

Always tired, grumpy about dance, a sore spot that won't go away, or worries at bedtime? **Tell Mom.** A lighter day is part of the plan, and the memory run is the light version.

PART 6

# Ways to fit it all in

**Same time, same place.**
Start practice at the same time on Thu, Fri and Sun. A habit is easier than making yourself do it.

**Big thing first.**
Homework, then practice, then free time.

**Best time on a home day:**
a small snack after school, dance about 45 minutes later, dinner after. Never right after a big meal: wait 1½–2 hours.

**In the app too:**
on a home day the solo and the trio come first. The countdown door, the dare and the weekend games open once both are done ★. They live on Play, under Weekend games and Extras.

**Let the timer be the boss.**
The app times each part. When it says done, you're done.

**Plan on Sunday.**
Fill in page 6 and look at the week: tests, parties, rehearsals.

**Pack tonight.**
Dance bag and water bottle by the door the night before.

**Stuck? Do the tiniest step.**
Put on dance clothes and start the warm-up. Starting is the hardest part.

PART 7

# When to use screens

**The app is a tool.**
Open it, practice, close it.

**Paper first.**
Planning, stickers, reading your fixes and Show in your head all happen on paper or with your eyes closed.

**Filming?**
The phone goes on its stand at the side, not in your hand.

**Screens off 1 hour before bed.**
Phones and tablets sleep outside your room.

**Screen-free swaps:** draw a costume idea, read, play outside, bake with Mom, freestyle to your favorite song, build a blanket fort.

PART 8

# Food for dancing

Dancing burns lots of energy, and food is your fuel. Every idea here is fish-and-veggie friendly.

EVERY MORNING

### Breakfast

Oatmeal with berries, eggs and toast, yogurt with granola, or a waffle with peanut butter.

1–2 HOURS BEFORE CLASS

### A small snack

Banana + peanut butter, apple + cheese, yogurt, crackers + hummus, or trail mix.

AFTER CLASS

### Eat again

Chocolate milk, Greek yogurt, eggs, a tuna or salmon sandwich, a bean-and-cheese quesadilla, or edamame.

EVERY DAY

### Grow strong

A rainbow of fruits and veggies. Milk, yogurt or cheese for strong bones. Beans, lentils, eggs, fish and spinach for energy.

**Water bottle at every class.** Sip before, during and after. Pale yellow pee means you're good. Dark means drink more.

**Never skip a meal. Dancers run on fuel. Growing bodies change and need lots of food. Strong dancers eat well. On show day, eat foods you know and nothing new.**

PART 9

# Sleep is secret practice

## 9–12

### hours every night

That's what kids your age need. While you sleep, your brain saves the steps you practiced, and your muscles repair and grow.

I wake up at **7:00** so lights out by **9:00 pm** for 10 hours.

**Same bedtime every night,**
weekends too.

**Late studio nights (Mon, Tue):**
dinner, the memory run on Tuesday, shower, bed. Homework is already done.

**Wind down:**
shower, PJs, a paper book, lights out.

**Show in your head in bed**
is optional. It never makes bedtime later.

PART 10

# Take care of your dancer body

Your body does all your dancing. Here's how to tell normal sore from stop-and-tell.

### Normal: keep going

Muscles that burn while you work. Tired, achy legs the next day. A stretch you can feel that doesn't hurt.

### Stop and tell Mom

Sharp or stabbing pain. Pain in a knee, ankle, wrist or your back. Swelling, limping, or pain that wakes you up or lasts more than a few days.

- ★ **Warm up first, always.** Stretch only warm muscles. A stretch, never pain. No oversplits.
- ★ **Stop before you're too tired.** Tired teaches your body the wrong way.
- ★ **Rest counts as training.** No dancing at home on Monday (videos and picturing only), and the rest-up days are rest on purpose.
- ★ **Nervous?** Smell the flower (breathe in for 4), blow out the candle (out for 6). Three times.
- ★ **Acro on the mat or with a spotter.** Kick-overs and aerials only in class.
- ★ **Knees over toes** in every plié, lunge and landing.
- ★ **Happy feet:** toenails short, check for blisters, socks off for floor work.
- ★ **Be kind to yourself.** Mistakes are how dancers learn. Say what went well first.

## For Mom

Be the stage crew, not the teacher: music, timer, filming, stickers. Ask, don't correct ("What comes next?"). Praise the work, not the talent. More on Toolkit page 3.

Sleep: AASM pediatric sleep consensus (2016)

Screens: AAP Family Media Plan

Rest and training load: Jayanthi et al. 2015

Made Oct 26, 2026, updated Nov 2. When the plan changes, the app has the newest version.